

STARTER

Common Refusal Reasons & How to Avoid Them

United States - F-1 Student Visa

Most F-1 refusals are issued under INA Section 214(b) - the same presumption-of-immigrant-intent standard used for the B-2 visitor visa, but examined here through your study plan, funding, and post-graduation intent specifically.

The most common specific reasons

1. Unconvincing post-graduation intent

The officer isn't convinced you intend to leave the US after completing your studies. Vague or generic answers about your plans after graduation are a common, avoidable gap.

2. Weak or unclear study plan

- Not being able to explain why you chose your specific program and school
- A mismatch between your academic background, your chosen major, and your stated career goals

3. Funding that doesn't clearly match your I-20

If your financial evidence doesn't clearly cover the figure stated on your I-20, or you can't explain your funding source clearly, this directly undermines your case - see the Financial Requirements Overview (Essential tier).

4. Weak ties to your home country

Evidence of family, property, a job offer, or other concrete plans that give you a genuine reason to return help establish nonimmigrant intent.

5. Inconsistent or incomplete documentation

Gaps between your DS-160, your I-20, and your interview answers undermine an otherwise solid case.

NO FORMAL APPEAL

A 214(b) refusal is a consular officer's discretionary finding, and there's no administrative appeal against it. See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for what actually helps, and how your school's Designated School Official (DSO) can sometimes defer your program start date if you're refused close to term start.